

3, What Factors in Japanese History Were Unfavorable to Feudalization?

Since the *Samurai* had already grown into the pillar of Japan's military power during the Heian period, the greatest difficulty encountered by Japan's **feudalization** (封建化) was actually not on the military level.

If one must point it out, the most dangerous military crisis the Japanese *Samurai* ever faced was rather the Yuan Dynasty's amphibious invasions of Japan. As for the *Kuge* (court nobles) who stood in opposition to the *Buke* (warrior houses) regarding state power (*this opposition refers to the overall historical process, not that they were always opposed at every moment*), they inherently lacked armed forces sufficient to confront the *Samurai*. This is entirely different from the Chinese court, which could use whips to drive hundreds of thousands of commoners as cannon fodder in war.

In my view, a highly fascinating phenomenon is that many cultural products about *Samurai* I have seen—whether created by the Japanese themselves or by Europe and America—ultimately emphasize "*overcoming oneself*" (战胜自己) more than "*defeating the enemy*."

This historical memory possesses a wondrous accuracy, because the genuine difficulty of Japan's **feudalization** lay precisely in the *Samurai*'s need to "overcome themselves"—they had to overcome the inherent conservatism of feudalism, while simultaneously forming their self-awareness and class assertions (阶级主张).

If we consider Europe's **feudalization** process, this difference becomes much easier to discern. For the *barbarians* (蛮族) entering civilized regions, they lacked any mature political system internally. Their **productive forces** (生产力) had developed to the extent that required establishing corresponding feudal **relations of production** (生产关系). Therefore, they merely needed to militarily defeat the remnants of the empire and occupy the lands the empire once held.

Aside from China, no other **classical empire** possessed such a comprehensive **bureaucratic system**. For the *barbarians*, it is even hard to say there was anything that needed to be destroyed, because once the social conditions for class substitution vanished, a general classical bureaucratic system would naturally wither away. The establishment of the feudal system was an exceedingly natural process.

In Japan, however, the *Samurai* themselves were born and rose to power *under* the political system of the mid-to-late Heian period. They had to seize power from within to attain political dominance; accomplishing such an enterprise was inextricably linked to resolve and ambition.

First, let's look at the initial point: what is the "inherent conservatism of feudalism"? This actually means that if a typical **feudal society** (封建社会) is compared to the eras before and after it, it is considerably lacking in the desire to expand, let alone expanding its own systems to other regions.

Let us now observe the situations before and after **feudal society**. First is the **early state** (早期国家), where the slavery system serves as the primary mode of exploitation. Next is the **classical state** (古典国家) during the transition from the slavery system to the feudal system. Then is the **feudal state** (封建国家), with the feudal system as its main body. Following that is the **early modern state** (近世国家 / absolute state) during the transition from the feudal system to capitalist society. Finally, there

is the typical bourgeois democratic state—i.e., modern society (*temporarily referred to according to domestic Chinese standards*).

Among these five stages, the expansiveness of the **classical states** and **early modern states** adjacent to the **feudal society** needs no emphasis whatsoever. The former forged a batch of great empires that are still yearned for by the people of their successors today. The latter initiated the most drastic population migrations and political map transformations in recorded human history, achieved through the Age of Discovery and subsequent colonial activities.

Moreover, this expansion was not only reflected in territory but also in culture and institutions. For example, the Han Dynasty established commanderies and counties (郡县) in conquered regions, deeply influencing the entire East Asia with Han culture. The first batch of states established in Southeast Asia almost all modeled themselves after India, to the point that originating from India was a crucial prerequisite for becoming a high-ranking priest or scholar.

Alexander's Eastern Campaigns left behind a vast Hellenistic world (希腊化世界), where Greek culture encountered and influenced Eastern cultures such as Buddhism. The Roman Empire's influence on the Mediterranean world goes without saying; as for the Byzantine Empire, which styled itself as the orthodox successor of Rome, during most of its existence it had long lost control of the Apennine Peninsula, being built entirely upon territories once conquered by Rome.

As for the cultural and institutional expansion of absolute **early modern states**, it likewise needs no mention; one simply needs to take a casual glance at the regimes currently existing in the New World, and the answer is self-evident.

Moreover, the **early states** (早期国家)—which were slavery-based and predated **classical states**—also harbored an urgent need to launch foreign wars.

This was not only because the source of legitimacy for the rulers of **early states** still inherited the traditions of the clan commune period—namely, the ruler needed to demonstrate his leadership and martial prowess through military victories. It was also because, under a mode of exploitation dominated by the direct exploitation of labor, manpower occupied the position of the **primary factor of production** (首位生产要素). Acquiring more slaves was essential for maintaining the state.

We might as well formulate a simple hypothesis: in an **early state**, there is an inequality in status and wealth among aristocrats, freemen, and slaves. Excluding factors like intermarriage, class mobility, and violent slaughter, the population of the aristocracy obviously grows faster than that of the slaves. This is because the upper classes clearly possess better conditions for raising offspring, whereas it is extremely difficult for the destitute masses to even leave behind descendants (*thinking of China's current demographic situation, I cannot help but sigh deeply*).

Therefore, in order to maintain the relative balance of domestic class forces and the existing production order, replenishing slaves through trade and war became crucial.

The Shang Dynasty in our country is a highly typical example. The Shang kings frequently had to launch military expeditions against peripheral "uncivilized peoples," plundering populations and using some as sacrificial offerings to consolidate their own power. Middle Eastern **early states**, such as Assyria, likewise have numerous records of forcibly relocating populations. The military operations of **early states** caused their cultures and systems to expand beyond their borders. For

example, during its zenith, Egypt perennially advanced up the Nile to attack the Nubia region; subsequently, an **early state** deeply influenced culturally by Egypt formed in this area.

The slave trade similarly leads to class differentiation in the slave-exporting regions, eventually propelling them into a slavery society, a phenomenon glaringly obvious in Africa during the Age of Discovery.

As for the typical bourgeois democratic states that emerged later than the **early modern states** (近代国家)—whether they are what Lenin called imperialist states, or the modern Western states after the United States dominated the international order—they do not necessarily desire direct control over vast territories and populations. However, their "capitalist" demands for opening markets and conducting investments are exceedingly robust.

This is because, among the three **primary factors of production** that successively occupied the apex—labor, land, and capital—it seems only capital views *self-expansion* (增殖 / in the political context of China, it is hard to imagine a better term, but it essentially means continuous accumulation and growth) as its lifeblood. Consequently, it possesses a intense drive for perpetual expansion.

Even if capitalist states harbor no good intentions, they inevitably hope that the systems of other countries—especially those with massive economic potential—are conducive to capital expansion. For instance, when China attempted to join the World Trade Organization (WTO), Western countries led by the United States were highly concerned about the issue of China's market economy system, hoping China would make certain changes (*from the standpoint of the Chinese common people, these were naturally progressive changes beneficial to the people*).

In contrast, a typical early feudal regime lacked such desires for territorial expansion and institutional export.

From our contemporary perspective, the era of **feudalization** (封建化) as a whole is already in the past, and we can no longer experience it intuitively. But based on deduction, the explanation I offer is this: the early feudal era was a period when the basic unit of production shrank to its absolute minimum since the advent of human class differentiation.

There was neither the collective labor of tens of thousands of people from the slavery period, nor the dozens of territory-expanding legions from the classical period, nor the prosperous handicraft and commercial towns of the **early modern** period—let alone the era following the Industrial Revolution, where it is hard for anyone to isolate themselves from the rest of the world.

The characteristics of the early **feudal society** (封建社会) are glaringly obvious: a self-sufficient, small-scale **natural economy** (自然经济) could form even within a very small scope, and its circulation was extremely limited. Based on this economic model, the administrative power of the **feudal lords** (封建领主) was heavily restricted, and state power plunged into a recession.

In fact, there is extremely tangential yet compelling evidence proving that this tendency indeed exists: a large array of religions that remain active in the world today achieved widespread dissemination globally precisely from the early stages of **feudalization** (封建化).

This includes Catholicism in Western and Central Europe; Orthodoxy in Eastern Europe; Islam from Senegambia all the way to Java; Hinduism in the subcontinent (*particularly the Bhakti movement* / 巴克提运动); Dianmi (滇密 / Yunnan Esoteric Buddhism) in the Dali Kingdom and the

Pagan Kingdom of Myanmar; Tibetan Buddhism in Tibet and Mongolia (*this description here is not entirely accurate, and I will discuss Tibetan Buddhism again later*); Daoism and Buddhism in the Chinese interior from the Eastern Han to the Northern and Southern Dynasties; and Japanese Buddhism during Japan's *Chūsei* (Middle Ages).

Why did world religions rapidly replace **classical state** religions and achieve widespread dissemination right when the entire world stepped into the early stages of **feudalization**?

The most rational explanation is that when secular power began to become absent at the grassroots level of society, religion naturally filled this ecological niche (生态位). These illustrious major religions possessed religious orders (教团), and their clerics were absolute intellectuals within local societies, capable of playing roles in arbitration and mediation. This point is manifested extremely clearly in the tales of *Effendi* (阿凡提 / Nasreddin) popular from China's Xinjiang to Turkey.

World religions brought a certain degree of organization to the fragmented societies of early **feudalization**. Worship, pilgrimage, and ascetic practices allowed society to maintain a form of circulation that transcended mere economic needs. It constructed an ideology suited for the feudal era, particularly providing the answer to why **feudal lords** (封建领主) possessed the legitimate right to rule the lands under their jurisdiction.

In fact, the Islam we speak of today was so incredibly successful during early **feudalization** that it ironically became an obstacle hindering Islamic countries from entering modern society. This means the grassroots organization around mosques during early **feudalization** was *too* successful, becoming a drag when state power was to be reconstructed in late **feudalization**.

Another counterexample from China illustrates this point even more vividly: the highly renowned "Disasters of Wu and Zong" (三武一宗灭佛 / the Four Buddhist Persecutions in China). Their time span stretched from the mid-5th century CE to the mid-10th century CE, which precisely coincided with the period when China's **bureaucratic system** was comprehensively restored (*beginning in the Northern and Southern Dynasties and completing in the Song*).

This counterexample demonstrates that China's despotic rulers recognized the fact that religion competed with state power in grassroots organization. Therefore, once they decided to restore the **bureaucratic system**, they had to destroy the Buddhist monastic orders (僧团). The fact is, these "usurpers of the state" (窃国之贼) achieved their goal. The theories and organizations of Han Chinese Buddhism became increasingly hollow; by the twilight of the Chinese Empire's rule, it had decayed beyond recognition, to the point that throughout the Yuan, Ming, and Qing dynasties, right up to today, Tibetan Buddhism has ironically been viewed as "higher Buddhism" in China.

On the other hand, after entering the feudal era, land became the most critical means of production. This spurred the gradual germination of consciousness surrounding land possession. Coupled with the development of new lands, the point-and-line (点线式) rule characteristic of **classical empires** and earlier slavery kingdoms passed into history (*this, of course, also refers to frontiers*).

By the feudal era, the borders between lords became clear and explicit. Once someone attempted to shatter the *fait accompli* with armed force, it would inevitably arouse the vigilance of surrounding lords. Today we know that wars aimed at annexing territory during the feudal era heavily emphasized having a "just cause" (师出有名 / *Casus Belli*). For example, in the game *Crusader*

Kings, without a claim (宣称) derived from inheritance laws, it is exceedingly difficult for both the player and the AI to expand.

Whether the real Middle Ages was this strict I cannot say for certain, but there is no doubt that back then, challenging the status quo collectively maintained by various lords exacted a colossal cost. The low capacity of the state also meant that lords lacked strong expansionist desires, because even if they nominally acquired new territories, managing them was difficult, and ultimately they would have to entrust the new fiefs to vassals. Whether the vassals would be loyal and whether they could deliver sufficient benefits became one problem; whether new neighboring countries harbored hostile designs became another.

Therefore, sometimes after expanding, **feudal lords** found that far from becoming stronger, they had merely invited a host of troubles. Even if a powerful feudal ruler conquered massive territories, he had to face the reality that such territories were administratively unsustainable; he might even have to partition the empire equally among his sons.

Throughout the early feudal era, it was highly normal for inheritance laws to lean toward **partible inheritance** (析产制), because labor based on the small family unit was more efficient. This was also reflected in the early history of the Japanese *Samurai*: the *Myōji* (苗字 / surnames) of many famous *Samurai* families we see today originally derived from the place names of manor territories divided through partible inheritance.

All the facts above demonstrate that for early feudal rulers, compared to their ruler counterparts before and after them, the costs of expansion were colossal, while the benefits were minimal and fraught with uncertainty. Under self-sufficient social conditions, exporting institutions externally appeared even more meaningless.

The drastic territorial expansions we see today during the early-to-mid **feudalization** period—which ultimately established feudal systems in conquered territories—were often conducted as **feudal holy wars** (封建圣战) under the aegis of religion. Examples include the Eastern Crusades (东征) of the German Teutonic Order, and the *Jihad* (吉哈德) launched by frontier Muslim regimes (*frontier relative to those far from Baghdad*).

Similarly, in the Iberian region—where the power balance between regimes frequently reversed—the religious fervor of both Catholicism and Islam was exceedingly high, and the two sides waged holy wars against each other countless times. Although the Crusades aimed at the Holy Land ultimately failed, they did once establish regimes featuring Western European feudal systems on the eastern shores of the Mediterranean.

For a secular feudal ruler unable to effectively harness religious fanaticism (*for instance, when neighboring rulers share the same faith*), his need to protect his borders and secure the peace of his people (保境安民) indeed often outweighed the desire to expand territory (开疆拓土).

From the standpoint of subordinate rulers, the vassals (封臣) could not possibly hope for their lord to constantly win battles, because the stronger their lord or his family became, the relatively weaker the vassals' power would be. Even with the existence of feudal contracts, maintaining a relative balance of power was always the first imperative to ensure the security of one's own fief.

In actual warfare, the army was no longer a state-owned "official army" (官军) like those in the past or future, but rather a coalition army composed of the individual troops of many lords. If a lord

wanted to fully unleash the military potential within his domain, he could not solely conscript troops from his direct demesne (直辖领地); he similarly needed to summon his vassals to participate in the war.

Since **feudal lords** (封建领主) of all sizes regarded their fiefs as their hereditary foundations, it was perfectly normal to adopt a passive attitude of preserving one's own strength in a war where it was difficult to profit even in victory. Conversely, for any defensive war where defeat would result in the loss of their own territory, there was probably no lord who would not go all out.

Whether in Japan or Europe, when people mention the Middle Ages, the first thing that usually comes to mind is the countless castles and fortresses dotting the land. In a society that was literally "heavily fortified" (壁垒森严), launching an offensive required the utmost caution, and returning without success was entirely commonplace.

Finally, one must absolutely not forget the actual distribution of the ruling class—that is, the **feudal lords**—under the specific economic conditions of a **feudal society**. *(From here on, I have decided to make a distinction to overcome the influence of the domestic Chinese context: I will only refer to the landowners who rely on rent-tax as their primary mode of exploitation under our country's restoration-bureaucratic system as "landlords" / 地主, and refer to all others universally as "feudal lords" / 封建领主).*

Compared to the preceding slavery-based aristocracy and the subsequent bourgeoisie (资产阶级), **feudal lords** exhibited a distinct characteristic of dispersion in their geographical distribution. This is because the former [**feudal lords**] had to reside in their fiefs, or at least periodically return there for a time, to maintain control over the land and its appendages (including people), whereas the latter [ancient nobles and modern bourgeoisie] were highly concentrated in city-states and towns.

Today, when people mention ancient Egypt, ancient Western Asia, and the Indus Valley civilization, the first thing that comes to mind is a series of ancient cities that remain famous even today. China was the same: the aristocrats of the Shang and Zhou dynasties ruled the state from within cities, and it was not until the Warring States period that the distinction between *Guoren* (国人 / urban dwellers) and *Yeren* (野人 / rural dwellers) completely disappeared.

As for the bourgeoisie, there is even less need to elaborate. The commercial and industrial cities that arose in the late Middle Ages, as hubs concentrating fully-equipped populations (especially high-quality human capital), wealth, materials, and information, were clearly the stage for the rising bourgeoisie to unleash their capabilities.

The aggregation of the ruling class forced them to interact more frequently, thereby making it easier to generate consensus and form collective decisions. Conversely, once the ruling class was distributed too broadly, consensus and collective decision-making were not easily generated. The emergence of localism (地方主义) was fundamentally inevitable, making it difficult to form the perspective of "*we have common class interests*."

Considering the above reasons comprehensively, the "inherent conservatism of feudalism" is not difficult to understand. As the population grew, the economy developed, towns boomed, and a massive number of nobles with no inheritance rights or very low inheritance priority emerged—and most importantly, as the feudal system consolidated and the social order restructured—this conservatism gradually disappeared.

This conservatism was not very likely to cause disastrous consequences in **feudalization** (封建化) regions that had experienced the Great Migrations (民族大迁徙). After all, if a feudal regime was surrounded by a forest of other feudal regimes, even if the borders changed, "*the meat rots but stays in the pot*" (肉烂了还在锅里 / *meaning the resources and spoils merely circulated internally without altering the overall feudal nature*); the social system itself would not experience a reversal.

For regimes on the periphery of feudal regions, even if they could not actively expand into *unfeudalized* areas, it was sufficient as long as they could defend their territories against more backward *barbarians*.

It is very easy to observe that Europe was situated in exactly such an advantageous position. It is a massive peninsula extending from the western tip of the Eurasian continent; overall, it is vulnerable to attack only from one direction: the east.

This meant that the intensity of the *barbarian* impact on an already *feudalized* Europe—particularly the impact of an *unfeudalized* people with a special mode of production, namely nomadic peoples (游牧民族)—was vastly smaller compared to East Asia and the Middle East.

Even at the zenith of their power, the threat posed by the Nordic Vikings to the European continent bore absolutely no comparison to the nomadic empires of the Asian steppes that routinely swept across thousands of kilometers. The fact is, before the Vikings could inflict systemic destruction on the overall **feudalization** achievements of the European continent, they themselves rapidly *feudalized*.

However, in East Asia, because of the formidable strength of China's remnant **bureaucratic system**, the inherent conservatism and sluggishness of the **feudal lords** (封建领主) were sufficient to grant the bureaucratic system the breathing room necessary to prepare its reactionary counterattacks.

When we look back at history, we see so many tragedies that occurred on this continent: the military commanders of the Southern Dynasties (*represented typically by the generals commanding personal retinues / Buqu in Eastern Wu, and the refugee commanders / Liumin Shuai leading armed displaced persons in the Eastern Jin*) were suspected, restricted, suppressed, and divided by the court. They failed to overpower the monarchs residing in Jiangzuo as guests, and never formed a "class interests coalition" (阶级利益共同体). Once the Liu clan achieved absolute dominance through military brilliance, they were desperate to restore the monarch-subject order, deeply terrified that posterity might follow in their own footsteps.

The Eastern Wei of the Northern Dynasties had twice the population of the Western Wei, yet failed to rapidly translate this into a military advantage, allowing the Guanzhong (关西) region to complete the initial restructuring of its **bureaucratic system**. The actual ruler, the Gao clan (高氏), lacked a stance of **feudalization**. Various conspiracies ran rampant within the state; by the time the Gao clan gave up being Shoguns (幕府将军) and reluctantly sat upon the supreme throne, the political situation remained turbulent, ultimately leading to their destruction by the Northern Zhou.

As for the frontier warlords (*Fanzhen* / 藩镇) that arose in the mid-Tang Dynasty, there is even less need to mention them. They could not even govern their own fiefs competently, and were perfectly content as long as the court's hands could not reach them for a single day. Pushing the feudal system nationwide was something they did not even dare to imagine.

The above basically concern the core regions of China. If we cast our gaze to the frontiers, we will find that similar situations existed there as well. The most typical examples are the Nanzhao (南诏) and Dali (大理) regimes established in Yunnan Province (*the brief transitional regimes in between can be ignored*).

Nanzhao was a **classical empire** modeled after the Tang Dynasty; it was not only capable of fighting but also highly bellicose, even eventually being dragged down by wars. The Dali Kingdom that arose subsequently was a regime with a highly advanced degree of **feudalization**, but this regime frequently plunged into civil wars and political turmoil. Let alone launching foreign wars, even its diplomacy became highly strained; it was only when Dali's history was half over that it established diplomatic ties with the Song Dynasty.

These feudal regimes, or regimes with a high degree of **feudalization**, that once appeared on the continent—whether due to lack of capability, lack of will, or a combination of both—always gave off a sensation of "sitting still" (静坐) during their existence. They just waited and waited, until they were finally annihilated by enemies they could not overcome.

Japanese *Samurai* similarly harbored this tendency. Taira no Masakado (平将门), despite raising an army and declaring himself the "New Emperor" (新皇) in rebellion against the court, still hoped the court would acknowledge the reality of his occupation of the Eight Provinces of Kanto. His mindset was simply to repel the official army if the court attacked.

After Minamoto no Yoritomo (源赖朝) opened the Shogunate in Kamakura, many direct vassals (*Gokenin* / 御家人) harbored a Togoku-centric (东国本位 / Eastern Japan-centric) ideology, viewing the Shogunate merely as an independent kingdom in Eastern Japan.

Fortunately, the Japanese court did not possess the capability to ultimately defeat and disintegrate the **feudal lords** like the Chinese court did. The Northern Fujiwara (奥州藤原氏) once built Hiraizumi into the nation's second-largest city, second only to Kyoto, yet their descendants could not even manage to be good "watchdogs of their households" (守户之犬).

If Japan's **bureaucratic system** had been just a little stronger, if the court had truly possessed an armed force, and if the rulers had had half the cunning and cruelty of their Chinese counterparts—using deceit and hypocrisy to divide and disintegrate the *Samurai* to buy time—how many more variables would have been added to Japanese history?

In the process of expanding and penetrating their ruling power nationwide, outstanding statesmen such as Minamoto no Yoritomo, Hōjō Masako (北条政子), Hōjō Yoshitoki (北条义时), Hōjō Yasutoki (北条泰时), and Ōe no Hiromoto (大江广元) rendered monumental contributions. In particular, the Shogunate's rapid and decisive handling of the Jōkyū War (承久之乱) is especially praiseworthy.

Stressing the word "speed" in all matters, always acting ahead of others, and never giving potential waverers the chance to sit on the fence or act capriciously—this was indeed an outstanding quality of the *Samurai* when facing sudden emergencies, exactly like the stories narrated in the *Konjaku Monogatarishū* (《今昔物語集》 / Anthology of Tales from the Past).

By the time of the Mongol invasions of Japan (元日战争), the Shogunate openly acted on behalf of Japan in international diplomatic arenas. Faced with the unprecedented threat of a homeland invasion, the Shogunate expanded the scope of the *Buke's* authority (武家权能).

In the face of a "national catastrophe" (天下大难), the Shogunate acquired greater legitimate cause (大义名分) from the court: anyone capable of fighting, regardless of whether they had a master-vassal relationship with the Lord of Kamakura (镰仓殿), could be mobilized by the Shogunate, and the Shogunate's scope for levying military rations was also expanded.

A massive number of *Gokenin* from the East went to Kyushu to participate in the defense and settled there, inevitably bringing Kanto consciousness and customs to the West. And because the threat of Mongol invasion might not disappear immediately, there was no explicit endpoint to the continuation of the state of war. In the joint enterprise of coping with the "Mongol Pirates" (元寇 / *Genkō*), the distinction between *Gokenin* and non-*Gokenin* also blurred.

Although this war imposed a massive burden on the Shogunate and accelerated its demise, the power of the *Buke* regime never regressed again. It was precisely on the foundation of the Shogunate expanding its authority nationwide and penetrating every domain that the *Samurai* could finally realize that **they themselves were the rulers of the state, and by no means merely acting as security guards defending the interests of the court and the aristocrats.**

This points to the second difficulty: the *Samurai* needed to realize that their class was the master of the entire state, rather than forever remaining the servants of the emperor and the aristocrats.

This problem was likewise unique to East Asia, because in regions where *barbarians* who had *Entered the Pass* (*Ru Guan* / 入关) spearheaded **feudalization**, there were absolutely no ideological difficulties to overcome. The *barbarians* inherently arrived with the identity of victors; this conquerors' spirit made them intensely certain that they themselves were the rulers of the state, and that Heaven willed them to govern the conquered lands.

Japanese *Samurai* lacked this identity. They stepped onto the historical stage as the mercenaries of the rulers. Thus, when facing the emperor and the *Kuge*, it was extremely normal for them to consciously feel inferior.

Moreover, from a Chinese perspective, it is very easy to point out that this was not merely a problem existing in ideology, but a very realistic political problem. Since ancient times, if one were to ask what technique the Chinese are most adept at, "political manipulation and persecution" (整人) would undoubtedly rank first. They may not have figured out much else, but when it comes to handling the ruled, their skills have reached absolute perfection (炉火纯青), and this ideology also indirectly affected regions peripheral to China.

In our country, there is an old saying: "*The gun shoots the bird that pokes its head out*" (枪打出头鸟).

One can fully imagine that Japanese *Samurai* once faced the exact same predicament. Even if individuals realized they should act as the rulers of the state, rashly raising an army remained a highly dangerous endeavor. This was because it was difficult to judge the stance of surrounding *Samurai*. While it was true that *Samurai* could forge alliances, for the others, accepting the court's decree to hunt down the rebel, striking down the "bird that poked its head out," and partitioning his territory was also a viable option—and one that appeared vastly less risky.

One must not forget that the emperor and the court held the "*legitimate cause*" (大义名分) in their hands. Ever since the Rebellion of Taira no Masakado, *Samurai* hunting down *Samurai* by the decree of the court was the historical norm.

The establishment of the Kamakura Shogunate was a momentous leap forward. The *Samurai* now possessed state apparatuses belonging to themselves; they could gather together, deliberate, form a consensus, and execute decisions. Therefore, when Retired Emperor Go-Toba (后鸟羽天皇) attempted to raise an army to annihilate the Shogunate (during the Jōkyū War), the Kanto *Samurai* realized for the first time that the importance of defending the collective interests of the *Samurai* class could supersede the pursuit of the interests of a single family or surname.

By the time Hōjō Yasutoki promulgated and implemented the *Jōei Shikimoku* (《贞永式目》 / The Jōei Formulary, also known as *Goseibai Shikimoku*), the *Samurai* had already acquired clear self-awareness and self-expression, desiring to establish an order dominated by the *Buke*.

The most commendable point is that the *Jōei Shikimoku* overcame the legal tradition inherited from China. It repudiated the notion that laws determining the order of the realm were obtained through sages "*handing down constitutions and setting models*" (垂宪作则). Instead, it recognized that laws should reflect the common interest demands of the ruling class, taking a historic step forward.

I believe the *Shikimoku* can be viewed as the definitive marker of Japan parting ways with China. From then on, the two countries never again approached one another in terms of social nature. China slid continuously down the path of bureaucratization, while Japan left all other Asian countries in the dust.

Even so, from the subjugation of the Taira clan right up until the demise of the Kamakura Shogunate, the Shogunate only confiscated the manor territories of hostile factions, never directing its spearhead at the *Kuge* themselves. The *Shōen-Kōryō* system (庄园公领制) of the late Heian period continued to persist in Japan.

When reading, I noticed that Japanese scholars also seemed astonished by this phenomenon: why, even more than a century into the *Chūsei* (Middle Ages), were annual tributes (*Nengu* / 年贡) from all over the country still being sent to Kyoto exactly as before? The authors could only sigh and deduce that people had perhaps become so accustomed to doing so that they felt it "*ought to be this way!*"

However, under such circumstances, although the *Samurai* acting as *Jitō* (地头 / estate stewards) did indeed possess partial land property rights by exercising police power, taxation power, and local management rights, the most crucial *absolute land ownership* still remained in the hands of the aristocratic manor lords. This meant a massive gap still existed between the *Samurai* and the **feudal lords** of Europe.

If we observe the post of *Shugo* (守护 / military governors) during the Kamakura period, it is not difficult to discover that this post was far from hereditary; rather, it corresponded to the *Kokushi* (provincial governors) under the *Ritsuryō* system. This also demonstrates that **feudalization** during the Kamakura period was still highly incomplete.

From the late Kamakura to the early Muromachi period, the *Jitō* expanded their dominating power through arbitration in the forms of *Jitō-uke* (地头请 / stewardship contracts) or *Shitaji chūbun* (下地中分 / physical division of land). The latter, in particular, allowed the *Jitō* to begin genuinely transforming into **feudal lords**.

Even more drastic changes occurred during the chaos of the Nanboku-chō (Northern and Southern Courts) period. Before this, it was one thing if *Samurai* quietly encroached upon aristocratic manors; but if they brazenly confronted the court, they would make themselves public enemies.

However, once Emperor Go-Daigo fled to Yoshino, one country shockingly possessed two emperors and two courts. People's awe and reverence for the *Kuge* instantaneously plummeted. Moreover, no matter which side one chose to attack, there was always an imperial edict from the *other* side providing a "*legitimate cause*." Thus, brazenly seizing the land of hostile aristocrats or *Samurai* no longer carried any psychological burden.

Japanese scholars are also forced to admit that the Nanboku-chō chaos lasted so long because the *Samurai* participating nationwide did not care in the slightest which emperor was the orthodox one. They prioritized considering which side they could join to obtain practical benefits.

The reason the Northern Court was ultimately able to achieve victory was probably still because the Muromachi Shogunate secured and expanded the territories of the *Samurai*—particularly massively strengthening the authority of the *Shugo*—leading *Samurai* everywhere to conclude that defecting to the Northern Court was the secure choice to preserve their existing territories!

When the two courts were unified, the land ownership of the *Samurai* expanded nationwide, the proportion of monistic control (一元化支配) over land increased, and the manors (*Shōen*) grew feeble. From this perspective, although the *Taiheiki* (《太平記》 / *Chronicle of Great Peace*) contains very few days of actual peace, the story it tells is indeed the path leading to the "Great Peace of the Realm."

Under precisely these conditions, the *Samurai* began to broadly realize that, as the ruling class of the state, it was perfectly justifiable for them to acquire power, and no mere "*legitimate cause*" (名分) could stop them.

Starting from the mid-Muromachi period, the phenomenon of *Gekokujō* (下克上 / the lower overcoming the upper) became extremely prevalent. We cannot view this as a question of loyalty or disloyalty, but must straightforwardly point out that **this was a widespread process in which the direct possessors of the means of production overthrew the indirect possessors through violent activities to acquire power and position. It was not a rebellion; it was a revolution.**

Accompanied by drastic social movements like *Gekokujō* and *Ikki* (一揆 / peasant and religious uprisings), the *Shōen-Kōryō* system continued to disintegrate. The Sengoku *Daimyos* (战国大名)—who could implement monistic control over their domains, possessed retainer bands (家臣団) with stringent master-vassal relationships, and resided in castles—stepped onto the historical stage.

Only at this moment could the *Daimyos* finally be said to be **feudal lords** (封建领主) identical to their European counterparts. (*Of course, people certainly cannot accurately demarcate the exact year they became identical and the year before which they were different. After all, Japanese society changed gradually in history, just as Europe could not possibly have remained static during the four to five centuries of the High and Late Middle Ages. In fact, I believe that when the Shugo domain system / 守护领国制 was basically established in the mid-Muromachi period, Japan's feudal system could be considered formed. Because during this period, the aristocrats' control over the manors had virtually vanished, and the Samurai completely controlled local regimes and land.*)

Japan had finally entered a typical **feudal society**; however, from the perspective of socioeconomic development, it had already reached the level of late feudalism. This is precisely why, under the banner of the far-sightedness and martial prowess of the three "*Tenkabito*" (天下人 / Unifiers of the Realm), Japan was able to complete the transition from a **feudal society** to an **early modern society** with such astonishing speed within a single century.

Here, the only point requiring people's special attention is this: before the West ended its **feudalization** process, entered **early modern society**, and experienced the explosive development of science and technology, the major civilized regions of the Eurasian continent—regardless of what systems they adopted—could not open up a decisive gap in the developmental level of their **productive forces** (生产力).

It is akin to Song Dynasty China, which was already entirely in a **restoration-bureaucratic society**, while Western Europe was simultaneously in the High Middle Ages. In reality, the level of **productive forces** in the Song Dynasty was completely sufficient to support China adopting the exact same social morphology as Western Europe during the High Middle Ages, only this possibility was strangled by political factors.

When observing Japan, it is not difficult to discover that Japan's *Chūsei* (Middle Ages) was, after all, different from Europe's. In Western Europe, the High Middle Ages (中世纪盛期)—the period when the feudal system was most mature and typical—was simultaneously the historical stage when the manorial economy was most prosperous.

But in Japan, the formation of the High Middle Ages society entirely dominated by **feudal lords** of all ranks proceeded simultaneously with the *decline* of the manorial system. This was because it was precisely the disintegration of Japan's manorial system that allowed the *Daimyos* to achieve monistic control over their territories.

From the perspective of economic development, the destabilization of Japan's manorial system occurred not much later than in Western Europe. The factors that would ultimately extinguish the manorial system at the economic level—the recovery of the **commodity economy**, the popularization of currency, the development of handicrafts, and the reclamation of new lands—were also identical.

This distinction between Japan and Western Europe still lay in their earlier political development. Japanese *Samurai*, after all, were not conquerors possessing a natural right to rule Japan. It took time for them to become an outstanding feudal ruling class in both strength and consciousness. In the process where the *Samurai*—acting as **feudal lords**—completely expelled the aristocrats (who originally held the ownership of the manors) from the stage of state politics, massive wars and widespread peasant uprisings inevitably accompanied them.

From the perspective of social restructuring in the Middle Ages, the historical process of Japan achieving this goal was clearly much more intense. Looking back from today's perspective, the most gratifying thing for the Japanese should be that although the wars of the Sengoku period were tragically brutal, their significance was indeed extraordinary. The rapid social transformations allowed Japan to massively close the gap with the historical trajectory of Western Europe, even though the complete disappearance of this gap had to wait until after World War II.

The history of the Edo period is something I dislike reading. This is because, as a Chinese person, if we can say that China at least skirted the edges of the feudal era, then when it comes to the **early modern** (近世) period in Japan, I find many things utterly incomprehensible.

My country never experienced such a stage, and even today, it lacks a genuine civil society (市民社会). The high development of the economy, the prosperity of *Chōnin* (町人 / townsman) culture, the germination of civil rights ideologies (民权思想), and calm, organized, disciplined uprisings go without saying.

What impressed me most was one author who converted the income of Japanese peasants in the late Edo period using the price of rice as a baseline. I discovered that the income of Japanese peasants at that time might have been even higher than that of present-day peasants in Henan province (*of course, we all understand that it is ultimately unreasonable to convert and compare incomes from an industrial society and an agricultural society based solely on the price of rice*).

What they did during their leisure time can perhaps serve as tangential proof. Even now, many peasants in China still need to take up odd jobs to make money during the agricultural off-season. In contrast, in that era, public activities among the Japanese populace were ridiculously abundant. Traveling far from home was highly common, and major events like the relocation of the Ise Grand Shrine (*Shikinen Sengū* / 伊势神宫迁宫) could even attract commoners from all over the country. If it weren't for the fact that many commoners had both money and leisure time, how could such activities possibly be sustained?

I can certainly read about these things in books, but I simply cannot acquire any intuitive feeling for them; I even have to read many concepts several times before I can understand them. Therefore, every time I see the achievements Japan made during the Edo period, I feel a deep sense of sorrow.

Fortunately, at least one country—Japan—was able to break through the arduous obstacles and move toward **early modernization and modernization** (近代化). At the very least, it wasn't a total wipeout for all of Asia (总归不是全亚洲都剃了光头). It proves, at minimum, that yellow-skinned people are capable of building and adapting to modern life, which in turn makes me feel happy for their success.

Thus, my first round of rough investigation into Japanese history has concluded. I can now generally grasp Japan's historical trajectory.

What satisfies me the most is clearly discovering that Japan's history can be fitted into the framework originally discovered regarding China, even if the two countries ultimately did not head in the same direction. Once the validity of this framework is increasingly confirmed through continuous testing, it will become a powerful research tool.

Even if, due to wildly divergent historical developmental paths, different countries only experience a portion of the entire sequence, we can still use the framework to deduce where a country is situated during a specific period. More importantly, we can provide a rational and universal explanation for its subsequent development. This would be an unprecedented achievement (前无古人的成就).

While reading, I continuously communicated with H. In fact, H consumes far more Japanese cultural products than I do. I am an utterly boring person with virtually no hobbies to speak of; I

have never watched any anime or series, nor do I have any interest in Japanese pop culture. H is different; he consumes his fair share of anime and outrageous light novels.

H agreed with my views on Japanese history and emphasized that its progressiveness is precisely the reason why Japanese culture is welcomed worldwide, especially in Western European and American countries.

Take the *Samurai* and the *Katana* for example. In truth, we were previously unaware of the *Samurai*'s contributions and the historical significance of the feudal revolution, yet we naturally harbored an affinity for such cultural imagery, finding it "cool."

H's assessment is that even if a person does not understand many profound principles, they will still be naturally attracted to things that possess progressive significance and historical contributions.

Perhaps humanity is inherently a species that pursues freedom and progress; no matter how arduous the environment one is born into, such a magnificent nature can never be completely obliterated.

3, 日本历史上存在哪些不利于封建化的因素

由于平安时代武士已经成长为日本军事力量的支柱，实际上日本封建化遇到的最大困难并非军事层面。非要说的话日本武士曾经面临的最为危险的军事问题反倒是元朝对日本的登陆作战，至于在国家权力方面与武家对立的公家（这里的对立是指从历史进程整体来看，不是什么时候都对立）本身没有足以与武士对抗的武装力量，这一点与中国朝廷能够用皮鞭驱使几十万百姓作为战争中的炮灰完全不同。在我看来一个非常有趣的事情是，我看到的很多关于武士的文化产品，不管是日本人自己创作的还是欧美创作的，最终都更强调“战胜自己”超过“击败敌人”。这种历史记忆有一种奇妙的准确性，因为日本的封建化真正的难点即在于武士需要“战胜自己”，既克服封建主义固有的保守性，又要形成自我意识和阶级主张。如果我们考虑欧洲的封建化进程就能更加容易地看出这种差异，对于进入文明地区的蛮族而言，他们自己内部没有什么成熟的政治体制，生产力发展到了需要建立与之匹配的封建生产关系的程度，因而只需要在军事上击败帝国的残存势力，占据帝国曾经的土地。除了中国以外也没有哪个古典帝国有如此完备的官僚制度，对于蛮族而言甚至很难说有什么东西需要被摧毁，因为一旦阶级交替的社会条件消失，一般的古典官僚体制自然就要消亡了，封建制度的确立就是非常自然的过程。在日本，武士本身就是在平安中后期的政治体制下诞生并崛起的，他们必须从内部夺取权力后取得政治上的主导地位，成就这样的事业离不开决心和野心。

首先看第一点，什么叫“封建主义固有的保守性”？这其实是说一个典型的封建社会如果向前和向后相比，那么它相当缺乏扩张欲望，更不用说把自身的体制扩张到其他地区。现在观察封建社会前后的情况，先是以奴隶制为主要剥削形式的（奴隶制）早期国家，然后是奴隶制向封建制过渡时的古典国家，再次是以封建制度为主体的封建国家，接着是封建制向资本主义社会过渡的近代（绝对主义）国家，最后是典型的资产阶级民主国家（暂时按中国国内的标准称呼）。这五个阶段里与封建社会相邻的古典国家和近代国家的扩张性完全不用强调，前者缔造的一批大帝至今仍为其继承者的人民所怀念，后者则开启了人类有记载历史上最为剧烈的人口迁徙和政治版图变化，这是通过地理大发现及其之后的殖民活动实现的。而且这种扩张不仅仅体现在领土上，也体现在文化和制度上，例如汉朝在被征服的地区设置郡县，整个东亚都深受汉文化影响；东南亚建立起的第一批国家几乎都在仿照印度，甚至于出身印度是成为高级祭司学者的一个重要条件；亚历山大东征之后留下了广大的希腊化世界，希腊的文化与东方的文化例如佛教相遇并产生影响；罗马帝国对于地中海世界的影响更不必提，至于以罗马正统自居的那个拜占庭帝国，在其存续的大部分时期也早就控制不了亚平宁半岛了，完全建立在罗马当年征服的领土之上。至于近世绝对主义国家的文化和制度扩张也不用提了，只需要随便看一下如今新大陆上存在的那些政权回答不言自明。

而比古典国家更早的（奴隶制）早期国家也有迫切发动对外战争的需求，这不仅是因为早期国家统治者的合法性来源仍然继承了氏族公社时期的传统，即统治者需要通过战争胜利展现其领导能力和勇武。也是因为以直接剥削劳力为主的剥削形式下，人力在所有生产要素中处于首要地位，获得更多奴隶对于维持国家是必要的。我们不妨做一个简单的假设，在早期国家中贵族、自由民和奴隶三者地位和财富不平等，在不考虑通婚、阶级流动、暴力杀戮这些因素下，显然贵族人口的增长要比奴隶快，因为上层阶级显然拥有更好的养育后代的条件，而赤贫百姓想要留下后代都极为困难（联想到中国现在的人口形势不由得长叹）。因此为了维持国内阶级力量的相对平衡和已有的生产秩序，通过贸易和战争的手段补充奴隶就变得重要了。我国的商代就是非常典型的例子，商王必须频繁的，对于周边的“未开化民族”进行军事讨伐，掠夺人口并且将一些作为祭品来巩固自己的权势，中东的早期国家如亚述也同样有不少强行迁移人口的记录。早期国家的军事行动使得自己的文化和制度扩张到了域外，例如埃及在强盛时期常年溯尼罗河而上进攻努比亚地区，后来这一地区便形成了在文化上受到埃及极大影响的早期国家。奴隶贸易同样会导致输出奴隶的地区产生阶级分化进而进入奴隶制社会，这在大航海时代的非洲是十分明显的。比近代国家更晚的典型资产阶级民主国家，无论是列宁所谓的帝国主义国家还是后来美国主导国际秩序之后的现代西方国家，他们倒不一定想直接控制多少领土和人口，但是对于开拓市场、进行投资之类“资本主义”的需求却相当旺盛。这是因为在三个相继居于顶点的生产要素：人力、土地和资本中，看来只有资本视增殖（我在中国的政治语境下很难想象用更好的词汇来描述，实际上就是说增长）为生命，因而有强烈的动力不断扩张。资本主义国家即使不出于什么好心，也必然是希望其他国家特别是有巨大经济潜力的国家的体制有利于资本扩张，例如在中国试图加入世界贸易组织时，以美国为首的西方国家就十分关心中国的市场经济体制问题，并且希望中国做出一些变化（站在中国老百姓的立场上，当然是进步的，有益于人民的变化）。

相比之下，一个典型的早期封建政权就缺少这样进行领土扩张和输出制度的欲望，站在现在的角度，封建化时期整体上已经成为过去，我们没办法再进行直观的体验。但是就推测来看，我给出的解释是，这是因为封建时代早期是人类阶级分化以来基本生产单位缩到最小的一个年代，既没有奴隶制时期成千上万人的集体劳动，没有古典时期十数个开疆拓土的军团，没有近代繁荣的手工业和商业城镇，至于工业革命之后就更不用提了，很难有人把自己隔绝于世界之外。早期封建社会的特征是这样明显，那就是在很小的范围内也能形成自给自足的小生产的自然经济，其流通极为有限。在这种经济模式的基础上，封建领主的行政力量受到了很大的限制，国家权力陷入衰退。

实际上有一个非常侧面的证据证明这种倾向确实存在，那就是在全世界各个地区的封建化早期到今天为止依然活跃在世界上的一大批宗教得到了广泛传播，西欧和中欧的天主教，东欧的东正教，从塞内冈比亚一直到爪哇的伊斯兰教，次大陆的印度教（特别是巴克提运动），大理国和缅甸蒲甘王朝的滇密（云南密宗），西藏和蒙古地区的藏传佛教（这里的描述并不准确，后面会再谈到藏传佛教），中国内地东汉至南北朝的道教和佛教，日本中世的日本佛教。为什么当全世界步入封建化早期时世界性宗教迅速取代了国家宗教并得到了广泛传播？一个最合理的解释就是，当世俗权力开始在社会基层缺位的时候，宗教就自然而然地填补了这一生态位。这些赫赫有名的大宗教具有教团组织，其教士在当地社会是绝对的文化人，能够起到仲裁和调解的作用，这一点在流行于中国新疆到土耳其的阿凡提的故事中体现得极为明显。世界性宗教为碎片化的封建化早期社会带来了一定组织，礼拜、朝圣和修行使得社会维持了一种超越经济需求的流通，构建了适合封建时代的意识形态，特别是为封建领主为什么合法地统治下土地这一问题提供了答案。实际上我们今天所谓的伊斯兰教在封建化早期实在太过成功，以至于反而成为伊斯兰国家难以进入近代社会的一个阻碍，就是指伊斯兰教在封建化早期围绕清真寺的基层组织太成功了，到封建化晚期国家权力重建的时候就成为了拖累。另一个来自中国的反面例子更加说明了这一点，这就是我国历史上大名鼎鼎的三武一宗灭佛，其时间跨度从公元五世纪中叶到公元十世纪中叶，而这正是中国官僚制度全面复辟的时期（始于南北朝，完成于宋）。这个反例说明中国的专制统治者认识到了宗教在基层组织中与国家权力产生竞争的事实，所以一旦要将官僚制度复辟，就必须破坏佛教的僧团。而事实就是，这些窃国之贼们实现了目标，汉传佛教的理论和组织变得越来越空洞，到中华帝国统治末期已经衰落得不成样子，以至于元明清三朝直到今天，反倒是藏传佛教在中国被视为“高等佛教”。

另一方面，进入封建化时代后土地成为最重要的生产资料，这使得围绕土地的占有意识逐渐萌生，加之新土地的开发，像古典帝国和更早的奴隶制王国那样点线式的统治过去了（当然这也是指边疆）。

等到封建时代，领主之间的边界变得清晰明确，而一旦要用武力破坏既有事实势必会引起周边领主的警惕。现在我们知道封建时代以兼并领土为目的的战争很注重师出有名，例如在游戏《十字军之王》中，没有来自继承法的宣称，无论是玩家和 AI 都很难进行扩张。现实中的中世纪是不是这样严格我不敢说，但是毫无疑问在当年要想挑战各领主共同维持的现状是要付出极大代价的。国家能力的低下也使得领主没有那么强烈的扩张欲望，因为就算名义上取得了新的领土但却难以管理的话，最终还是要将新的领地托付给封臣。封臣是否忠诚，能否为自己输送足够的利益就是一个问题，新的邻国是否有所图谋又是一个问题。所以有的时候封建领主在扩张之后发现自己非但没有变得更强，反而惹上了一堆麻烦。就算一位强大的封建统治者征服了极大的疆域，那么他不得不面临这样一个事实，这样的疆域从行政管理的角度已经不可维持了，所以他甚至需要把帝国均分给自己的儿子。在整个封建时代早期，继承法倾向于析产是很正常的，因为以小家庭为单位的劳动更具效率。这也体现在了日本武士的早期历史中，我们今天看到的很多有名的武士家族的苗字最早就是分割继承而来的庄园领地的地名。以上事实都说明对于早期封建统治者而言，相较于之前和之后的统治者同行，扩张的成本极大，而收益不大且具有不确定性，而在自给自足的社会条件下，对外输出制度就显得更没意义了。我们今天看到封建化前中期最终在被征服领土上建立封建制度的剧烈领土扩张往往是在宗教支持下通过圣战进行的，例如德国条顿骑士团的东征以及边疆的穆斯林政权（这个边疆是对远离巴格达而言）发动的吉哈德。同样的政权强弱发生逆转的伊比利亚地区，无论是天主教还是伊斯兰教宗教热情都极为高涨，双方互相圣战不知道总共多少次。以圣地为目标的十字军东征虽然最终失败，但是也曾经在地中海东岸建立过西欧封建体制的政权。而对于无法有效利用宗教狂热的世俗封建统治者来说（比如相邻的统治者都与自己同信仰），他对于保境安民的需求的确往往大于开疆拓土。

站在次级统治者的立场上，作为封臣的一方也不可能希望自己的领主总是打胜仗，因为自己的领主或者其家族越强大，封臣的力量就相对而言变弱小了。即使有封建契约的存在，但是力量的相对平衡始终是保证自己领地安全的第一要义。在实际战争中，军队不再是像过去或者将来出现的那种属于国家的“官军”而是许多领主各自军队的联军。一个领主如果想要充分发挥自己领内的军事潜力就不可能只从自己的直辖领地征兵，同样需要召集自己的封臣参与战争。既然大大小小的封建领主们都以自己的领地作为世袭的基业，那么在一场即使胜利自己也难以得利的战争中采取保存实力为上的消极态度就再正常不过了。反过来说，对于任何一旦战败就会导致自己领土丧失的防御性战争，恐怕没有哪个领主不会全力以赴应对。无论是在对日本还是欧洲，当人们提到中世纪这个概念时往往首先想到的就是在国土中数不清的城堡要塞，在这种字面上“壁垒森严”的社会，发动进攻就必须慎之又慎，而无功而返实在平常。

最后，千万不要忘记封建社会特定的经济条件下统治阶级也就是封建领主的实际分布情况（从这里开始我决定做区分以克服国内语境带来的影响，只将在我国官僚复辟体制下以租税为主要剥削方式的土地所有者称为地主，对于其他一律称为“封建领主”）。封建领主比起之前的奴隶制贵族和之后的资产阶级在分布上具有明显的分散性这一特点，这是因为前者必须处在领地或者至少定期返回领地一段时间以维持对土地及其依附物（包括人）的控制，而后者却相当集中在城邦市镇当中。现在人们提起古埃及，古代西亚，印度河文明首先想到的是一连串即使在今天依然闻名的古城。中国同样如此，商周的贵族在城市中统治国家，直到战国时期国人和野人的区分才彻底消失。至于资产阶级就更不必多说，中世纪晚期兴起的工商业城市作为设施完善的人口（特别是高质量人口），财富，物资和信息集中之地，显然是新兴资产阶级大展身手的舞台。统治阶级的聚集使他们之间不得不拥有更频繁的互动，因而更容易产生共识并形成集体决策。与之相反，一旦统治阶级分布太过广泛，共识和集体决策就没有那么容易产生，地方主义出现根本不可避免，要想形成“我们有共同的阶级利益”这样的观点就有了难度。综合考虑以上原因，“封建主义固有的保守性”就是不难理解的事情了，随着人口增多，经济发展，城镇勃兴，出现大量没有继承权或继承次序极靠后的贵族，当然最重要的还是封建制度的巩固社会秩序重组，这种保守性就逐渐消失了。

这种保守性在经历了民族大迁徙的封建化地区还不太容易造成恶果，毕竟一个封建政权如果周边也是林立的封建政权，就算边境发生变化毕竟肉烂了还在锅里，社会制度是不会发生逆转的。对于封建地区边缘的政权来说，即使不能主动对未封建化地区进行扩张，只要面对更加落后的蛮族能够保卫领土也就够了。人们很容易观察到欧洲就处于这样一种有利位置，它是一个欧亚大陆西端延伸出来的巨大半岛，整体来看只有东面一个方向容易受到进攻。这使得业已封建化的欧洲受到蛮族冲击，特别是一种具有特殊生产方式的未封建化民族即游牧民族冲击的力度比起东亚和中东小太多了。即使是北欧的维京人在最

强盛的时期，对欧洲大陆产生的威胁和亚洲草原那些动辄横扫上千公里的游牧帝国也没有任何可比性，事实就是，维京人在没有对欧洲大陆整体的封建化成果造成破坏的时候，自己也迅速地封建化了。

但是在东亚，因为中国残存官僚制度的强大，封建领主身上这些固有的保守和迟缓就足以让官僚体制获得准备反攻倒算的喘息之机。当我们回顾历史就会看到这片大陆发生过这样多的悲剧：南朝的军事统帅（以东吴统帅部曲的将领和东晋统帅难民武装的流民帅为典型）被朝廷怀疑、限制、打压、分化，不能压制客居江左的君主，没有形成利益共同体。一旦刘氏凭借军事才能独大，则急于恢复君臣秩序，唯恐后人能走自己的老路。北朝的东魏两倍人口于西魏，但是却无法迅速转化成军事优势，使得关西初步完成了官僚制度的重组。实际统治者高氏又缺乏封建化的立场，各种阴谋在国中大行其道，等到高氏放弃当幕府将军勉强坐上至尊的宝座政局却仍然动荡，最终被北周所灭。唐中期兴起的藩镇就更不用说，他们连自己的领地尚且治理不明白，朝廷的手一天伸不过来便心满意足，把封建制度推向全国是想都不敢想的事。以上基本还都是中国核心地区的事，如果我们把目光放到边疆会发现类似情况同样存在，最为典型的是在云南省建立的南诏和大理政权（中间短暂过渡的政权可以忽略）。南诏是一个效仿唐朝的古典帝国，不但能战并且好战，甚至最后也被战争所拖垮。随之而起的大理是一个封建化程度很高的政权，但这个政权就时常陷入内战和政治风波，不要说对外进行战争，甚至连外交都变得很勉强，当大理的历史走过一半的时候才与宋朝有了外交往来。这些大陆上曾经出现过的封建政权或者封建化程度较高的政权，或者因为没能力，或者因为没意愿或者两者兼而有之，在其存在的时间里总是给人一种“静坐”的感觉，等着等着，最后就被难以战胜的敌人消灭了。

日本武士同样存在这样的倾向，平将门既以起兵自称新皇反叛朝廷，却还是希望朝廷承认自己占有关东八州的现实，倘若朝廷来攻，将官军击退即可。在源赖朝于镰仓开幕之后，不少御家人存有东国本位的思想，仅仅将幕府视为东日本的独立王国。幸运的是，日本朝廷并没有中国朝廷一样拥有最终击败和瓦解封建领主的能力。奥州藤原氏曾经把平泉建设成为全国仅次于京都的第二大城市，可是子孙依然连守户之犬都做不好。假使日本的官僚制度再强一点，朝廷真的拥有一支武装力量，统治者有中国的同行一半的狡猾和凶残，用诈术和虚伪对武士分化瓦解来争取时间，那么日本的历史又要平添多少变数。在将统治权扩大并深入到全国的过程中，源赖朝、北条政子、北条义时、北条泰时、大江广元等杰出政治家立下了大功，特别是幕府在承久之乱中迅速果断的处置尤为令人称道。凡事讲究一个“快”字，永远抢在别人前面行动，不给潜在摇摆方坐观成败，反复无常的机会，这的确是武士在面临突发情况时的优秀品质，一如《今夕物語集》中叙写的故事一般。再到元日战争的时候，幕府光明正大地站在国际外交的场合代表日本行事，在前所未有的本土遭到入侵的威胁面前，幕府扩大了武家权能涉及的范围。在“天下大难”面前，幕府从朝廷那里获得了更多大义名分，只要有能力作战者，无论其是否与镰仓殿有主从关系皆可被幕府动员，幕府征收军粮的范围也扩大了。大量东国的御家人前往九州参加防御并在那里定居下来，必然会把关东的意识习惯带到西国。而元朝的入侵可能没有立刻消失，所以战时状态持续下去并没有一个明确的终点，在共同应对“元寇”的事业中，御家人和非御家人的差别也变得模糊。虽然这场战争给幕府造成了很大负担，加速了其灭亡，但是武家政权的权力却并没有再退回去。正是立在幕府将权能扩大全国并深入各个领域的基础上，武士才有可能意识到自己就是国家的统治者，而绝非只是扮演捍卫朝廷和贵族利益角色的保安。

这就是第二个难点，武士需要意识到自己这个阶级就是整个国家的主人，而非永远都是天皇和贵族的仆人。这个问题同样是东亚独有的，因为在入关蛮族主导封建化的地区根本不存在什么观念上的困难需要克服，蛮族本身就是以胜利者的身份到来，这种征服者的气概使他们非常确信自己就是国家的统治者，上天要自己治理被征服的土地。日本武士并没有这种身份，他们是以统治者的雇佣兵这一身份登上历史舞台，在面对天皇和公卿时产生自觉矮人一头是极为正常的事。而且以中国人的视角很容易指出这并不仅仅是一个只在观念上存在的问题，而且是一个非常现实的政治问题。自古以来，如果说中国人最擅长什么技术的话，那么首推整人，别的没玩明白，如何对付被统治者那是炉火纯青的，这种思想对于中国周边地区也会产生间接影响。在我国有句古话叫：枪打出头鸟。完全可以想象日本的武士也曾经面临这样的困境，就算有个别人意识到自己应该作为国家的统治者，但是轻易举兵仍是一件十分危险的事情。这是因为难以判断周围武士的立场，诚然武士们可以达成联合，但是对于其他武士而言，接受朝廷追讨叛逆的旨意打掉那个出头鸟，瓜分他的领地也是一个选择，而且看起来风险要小很多。不应该忘记的一点是，天皇以及朝廷手中捏着大义名分，从平将门之乱开始，武士以朝廷的旨意讨伐武士就是历史常态。镰仓幕府的成立是一次重大的进步，武士们有了属于自己的国家机关，能够聚在一起商议形成共

识并执行决策。因此当后鸟羽天皇试图起兵消灭幕府的时候，关东武士第一次意识到了维护武士阶级集体利益的重要性可以大于追求一家一姓的利益。到北条泰时颁布实施《贞永式目》，武士已经有了清晰的自我意识和自我表现，希望能够确立武家主导的秩序。最难能可贵的一点是，《贞永式目》克服了继承自中国的法律传统，否定了确定天下秩序的法律是圣人“垂宪作则”而得，认为法律应该反映统治阶级的共同利益诉求，迈出了历史性的一步。我认为《式目》可以视为日本同中国分道扬镳的标志，从此两个国家再没有在社会性质上接近过，中国在官僚化的道路上一路滑下去，而日本则把亚洲所有国家甩在后面。

即使如此，从讨伐平家直至镰仓幕府灭亡，幕府都只是从敌对一方没收庄园领地，并不把矛头指向公家本身，平安后期庄园公领制在日本继续延续下去。我读书的时候发现日本的学者似乎对这种现象也感到惊奇，为什么即使进入中世一百多年，全国各地的年贡还是像往常一样送往京都？作者都只能感慨大概是人们已经习惯了这样做，因而觉得“理应如此”吧！可是如此一来，作为地头的武士虽然确实通过行使警察权，征税权和下地管理权确实拥有了部分土地产权，但是最为重要的土地所有权还是在贵族庄园主手中，这使得武士和欧洲的封建领主仍然有极大差距。如果观察镰仓时期守护一职，那么不难发现这一职务远非世袭，对应于律令制下的国司，这也能看出镰仓时期封建化仍然很不彻底。从镰仓后期到室町前期，地头通过仲裁以地头请或下地中分的形式扩大了自己的支配权力，尤其是后者使得地头开始真正蜕变成为封建领主。更为激烈的变化发生在南北朝的战乱期间，在此之前，武士如果说悄悄蚕食贵族庄园也就罢了，如果悍然与朝廷对抗则会使自己成为众矢之的。可是等到后醍醐天皇逃往吉野，一个国家居然出现两个天皇，两个朝廷，人们对于公家的敬畏一下子就减弱了。况且无论选择进攻哪一方，总有另一方的圣旨能给自己提供大义名分，这样明目张胆地夺取敌对方贵族或是武士的土地也没有什么心理压力。日本学者也不得不承认，南北朝战乱如此之久，是因为加入全国武士们根本不在乎到底哪个天皇是正统，而优先考虑自己加入哪一方能够获得实际的利益。北朝之所以能够取得胜利，大概还是因为室町幕府确保和扩大了武士的领地，特别是极大加强了守护的权限，使得各地武士都认为投靠北朝是保住自己已有领地的稳妥选择吧！

当两个朝廷一统时，全国范围内武士土地所有权扩大了，土地一元化支配的比例提高，庄园变得衰弱，从这个角度上讲，《太平记》中虽然少有太平时日，但是《太平记》的故事确实是通往天下太平的道路。就是在这种条件下，武士开始广泛意识到自己作为国家的统治阶级理所应当要获取权力，这不是名分能拦得住的。从室町时代中期开始，“下克上”的现象变得十分普遍，我们不能将其视为忠诚或者不忠诚的问题，而应当直截了当的指出，这就是一种广泛的，生产资料的直接拥有者通过暴力活动推翻上级的间接拥有者获得权位的过程，它并非是谋反而是革命。随着下克上和一揆这样剧烈的社会运动，庄园公领制继续瓦解，能够对领内实施一元化支配，拥有严密主从关系的家臣团，居住在城堡中的战国大名走上历史舞台。直到这个时候大名才终于能够说是与欧洲同行一样的封建领主了，（当然人们肯定没办法准确地界定什么时候就从哪一年开始就一样，而这一年之前就不一样，毕竟历史中日本社会是在逐渐变化的，欧洲在中世纪盛期和晚期的四五百年间也不可能一成不变。其实我认为在室町时代中期守护领国制基本确立的时候，就可以算上日本的封建体制形成了，因为这个时期贵族对于庄园的控制几乎已经消失，武士完全控制了地方政权和土地）日本才进入典型的封建社会，不过从社会经济的发展情况来说已经达到了封建晚期的水平。这也是为什么在三代天下人的远见和武功的旗帜下，日本能以如此快的速度在一个世纪里完成封建社会向近世的过渡。

这里唯一需要人们特别注意的一点是，在西方结束封建化进程进入近世社会，科学技术爆炸式发展之前。欧亚大陆的主要文明区域无论其采取何种制度，在生产力发展水平上是拉不开决定性差距的。就好比宋代中国已经处于完全的复辟官僚社会中，此时西欧正处于中世纪盛期，那么实际上宋朝的生产力水平足以支持中国同样采取欧洲在中世纪盛期的社会形态，只不过这种可能被政治因素所扼杀了。我们在观察日本的时候不难发现日本的中世纪与欧洲毕竟不同，欧洲西部中世纪盛期，即封建体制最为成熟和典型的时期同样也是庄园经济最繁荣的历史阶段。但是在日本，由各级封建领主完全主导的中世盛期社会的形成是与庄园制度的衰落同时进行的，因为正是日本庄园制度的瓦解才能够让大名实现对领地的一元支配。从经济发展进程来说，日本庄园制度的动摇并不比西欧晚多少，商品经济恢复，货币普及，手工业发展，新土地开垦这些在经济层面最终会消灭庄园制的因素也是一致的。日本与西欧的这种区别还是在于早先政治发展，日本武士毕竟不是作为征服者对于日本具有天然的统治权，他们在力量上和意识上成为出色的封建统治阶级需要时间。在作为封建领主的武士将原本拥有庄园所有权的贵族完全从国

家政治的舞台上驱逐出去的过程中，会伴随有大规模的战乱和波及甚广的农民起义，从中世纪社会重组的角度来说，日本实现这一目标的历史进程显然更激烈。站在今天的角度来看，日本人最值得欣慰的事情应当是战国时代的战争虽然惨烈却的确意义非凡，迅速的社会变革让日本大大拉近了与西欧历史进程之间的差距，尽管这种差距完全消失最终还要等到二次大战之后。

江户时期的历史是我最不喜欢看的，这是因为作为一个中国人，如果说中国至少曾经封建时代的边绕了个弯，那么到了近世日本的很多事情我都已经无法理解了。我的国家没有经历过那样的阶段，直到今天也没有一个真正的市民社会。经济的高度发展，町人文化的繁荣，民权思想的萌发，有组织纪律的冷静起义自不必说。最让我印象深刻的是其中一位作者在通过米价为基准折算江户末期日本农民的收入，我发现那个时候日本农民的收入可能比现在河南农民还高（当然，我们也都明白把工业社会的收入和农业社会的收入都折合成米价进行对比总归是不合理的）。自从他们闲暇时间做的事情或许可以侧面证明，到现在中国很多农民在农闲时间还需要打工赚钱，而在那个年代日本民间的公共活动就多到离谱，出远门旅行也十分常见，像伊势神宫迁宫这种大事甚至能吸引全国各地百姓前来，如果不是很多百姓有钱有闲，怎么可能支撑这些活动办起来呢？这些事物我确实可以从书上读到，但是就是没办法获得任何直观的感受，很多概念甚至要读好几遍才能读明白。因此每次看到江户时期日本取得的成就就令我感到很难过，不过好在有日本一个国家能够冲破艰难险阻走向近现代化，总归不是全亚洲都剃了光头，至少能证明黄种人是能够建设并适应现代生活的，这又让我为他们的成功感到高兴。

就这样，我对于日本历史第一轮粗略的考察就这样结束了，我现在大体上能够掌握日本的历史进程。最令我感到满意的是，显然我发现日本的历史可以套在针对中国所发现的框架中，哪怕两个国家最终没有去往一个方向。一旦这个框架的有效性得到随着不断被检验而日益得到确认，它就会变成一种强有力的研究工具。哪怕因为历史发展路径千差万别，不同的国家只会经历全阶段的一部分，但我们也可以根据框架去推断它在某个时期处于哪个位置并且对于接下来的发展给出一个合理的，更重要的是普遍性的解释，这会是前无古人的成就。在我看书的过程中也一直和 H 进行交流，实际上 H 看的日本文化产品比我多得多，我是一个没有任何爱好可言的无聊透顶之人，什么动漫、番剧根本没看过，对于日本的流行文化也没有兴趣，H 就不一样，他看的动漫和逆天小说就一点不少。H 赞同我对日本历史的看法，并且强调其进步性恰恰是日本文化能够在全世界范围，特别是西方欧美国家都受到欢迎的原因。就拿武士、武士刀来说，其实我们之前并不清楚武士的贡献以及封建革命的历史意义，但是天然就对这样的文化意象有好感，认为很酷。H 的评价是，一个人即使并不懂太多道理，也会被这样有进步意义和历史贡献的事物吸引，或许人类本来就是一个追求自由和进步的物种，无论生在多么艰难的环境下也不能将这样伟大的天性完全磨灭吧。